

Projects in Great Nicobar Island have strategic importance

In the past five years, the government has taken steps to develop the Andaman and Nicobar Islands as a **bulwark** of security to the east of the country's peninsular area and as a crucial **node** for **safeguarding** India's interests in the Indo-Pacific. The project involves **revamping** airfields and **jetties** and building **logistics** and storage **facilities**, a base for military personnel, and a **robust surveillance infrastructure**. It also involves a massive infrastructure upgrade on Great Nicobar Island — an International Container Transshipment Terminal, a **greenfield** international airport, a township, and a gas and solar-based power plant spread. **Given** that the rapid **enhancement** of the capabilities of China's People's Liberation Army Navy has greatly increased the strategic importance of the Bay of Bengal in the past two **decades**, Delhi's infrastructure push and the building of a strong military **deterrence** at Great Nicobar hasn't come a day too late. However, the island's **ecological sensitivity** has made the challenge more complex. Civil society **activists** and wildlife conservationists have alleged that the infrastructure upgrade will harm the region's **indigenous** communities, including the largely uncontacted Shompen people, it will have negative **spinoffs** for **coral reefs** and marine systems and pose a threat to **endangered** species, including the **terrestrial** Nicobar megapode bird and leatherback turtles. In 2023, the National Green Tribunal (NGT) **directed** the Ministry of Environment to constitute a high-powered committee (HPC) to **revisit** the environmental clearances to the Great Nicobar project. On Monday, even as the ministry submitted the panel's report to an NGT **bench**, there was little indication that a **resolution** to the **impasse** was **at hand**.

The HPC has **reportedly concluded** that the environmental clearances **accorded to** the project "**adhered to statutory provisions**". The government has, however, not made the panel's report public. **Keeping** information **classified is**, of course, necessary **at times** in matters involving strategic affairs. But in an ecologically **fragile** region with a **vulnerable** local population, a **project** to create a **formidable** maritime **bastion requires** engagement with all sections of society. The government's **insistence** on secrecy **will** do more harm than good, especially because the lack of **transparency** around **due** procedures was a major **sticking point** with civil society activists. The government has **reportedly** also **wielded** the RTI Act's provisions on security and strategic concerns to deny right to information requests about environmental clearances. In March, it used an equally **unconvincing** argument — the matter is **sub judice** — to **evade** a Rajya Sabha question on the red flags raised by the NGT and National Commission for Scheduled Tribes about the project's impact on local communities. Two months later, Union Minister of Tribal Affairs Jual Oram said that the government was **examining** the concerns raised by tribal communities, but again refused to **divulge** details. The Andaman and Nicobar Islands Integrated Development Corporation Limited, which is in charge of the infrastructure development activities, claims that its wildlife conservation plan (WCP) is derived from a **framework** developed by scientists at the Salim Ali Centre for **Ornithology**. But the WCP, too, is not in the **public domain**.

Delhi has taken more than 70 years to recognise the strategic importance of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands. It now needs to set the record right on transparency — a project of national importance cannot be **clouded** with **misgivings**. [Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

@mocks_wallah

Vocabulary

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| <p>1. Bulwark (noun) – protection, defense, safeguard, rampart, shield सुरक्षा कवच</p> <p>2. Node (noun) – point, junction, hub, center, intersection केंद्र बिंदु</p> <p>3. Safeguard (verb) – protect, defend, secure, shield, preserve सुरक्षा देना</p> <p>4. Revamp (verb) – renovate, overhaul, renew, modernize, refurbish पुनर्निर्माण करना</p> <p>5. Jetty (noun) – pier, dock, wharf, landing stage, quay घाट / नाव उतरने का स्थान</p> <p>6. Logistic (noun) – supply chain, operations, planning, coordination, provision रसद</p> <p>7. Facilities (noun) – infrastructure, amenities, utilities, installations, services संस्थान</p> <p>8. Robust (adjective) – strong, sturdy, powerful, resilient, durable मजबूत</p> <p>9. Surveillance (noun) – monitoring, observation, watch, scrutiny, supervision निगरानी</p> <p>10. Infrastructure (noun) – framework, structure, foundation, facilities, base ढांचा / आधारभूत संरचना</p> <p>11. Greenfield (noun) – denoting or relating to previously undeveloped sites for</p> | <p>commercial development or exploitation. नया निर्माण क्षेत्र</p> <p>12. Given (preposition) – considering, in view of, based on, taking into account को देखते हुए</p> <p>13. Enhancement (noun) – improvement, boost, development, upgradation, augmentation सुधार</p> <p>14. Decade (noun) – Period of ten years, दशक</p> <p>15. Deterrence (noun) – prevention, hindrance, obstruction, discouragement, resistance निवारण</p> <p>16. Ecological (adjective) – environmental, biological, green, natural, eco-related पारिस्थितिक</p> <p>17. Sensitivity (noun) – awareness, concern, responsiveness, delicacy, consideration संवेदनशीलता</p> <p>18. Activist (noun) – campaigner, reformer, advocate, supporter, protester कार्यकर्ता</p> <p>19. Indigenous (adjective) – native, tribal, aboriginal, original, local आदिवासी / स्वदेशी</p> <p>20. Spinoff (noun) – side effect, by-product, consequence, outcome, secondary result द्वितीयक प्रभाव</p> |
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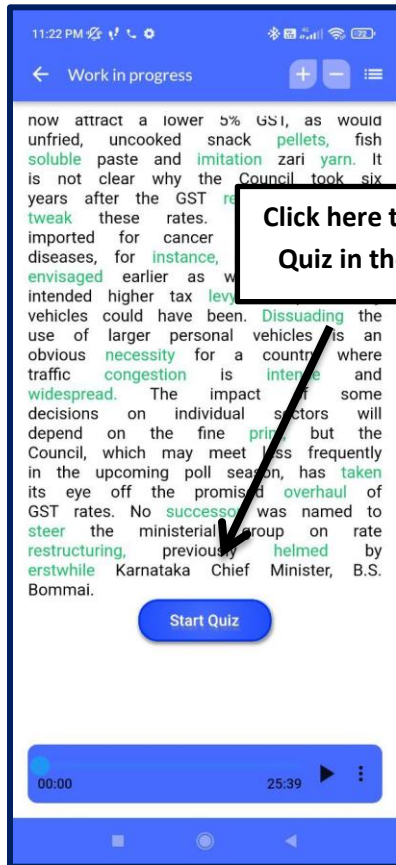
21. **Coral reef** (noun) – an underwater ecosystem characterized by reef-building corals प्रवाल भित्ति
22. **Endangered** (adjective) – threatened, at risk, imperiled, vulnerable, rare संकटग्रस्त
23. **Terrestrial** (adjective) – land-based, earthly, ground-dwelling, non-aquatic स्थलीय
24. **Direct** (verb) – order, instruct, command, guide, mandate निर्देश देना
25. **Revisit** (verb) – review, reassess, reconsider, re-examine, go over again पुनः विचार करना
26. **Bench** (noun) – judicial body, tribunal, court panel, judge's seat न्यायपीठ
27. **Resolution** (noun) – solution, settlement, decision, conclusion, remedy समाधान
28. **Impasse** (noun) – deadlock, stalemate, standstill, gridlock, logjam गतिरोध
29. **At hand** (phrase) – nearby, imminent, approaching, close, forthcoming पास में / निकट
30. **Reportedly** (adverb) – allegedly, supposedly, according to reports, as claimed रिपोर्ट के अनुसार
31. **Conclude** (verb) – determine, decide, judge, infer, deduce निष्कर्ष निकालना
32. **Accord** (to) (verb) – grant, give, bestow, provide, confer प्रदान करना
33. **Adhere** (to) (verb) – follow, comply with, obey, conform to, stick to पालन करना
34. **Statutory** (adjective) – legal, mandated, legislated, official, regulated वैधानिक
35. **Classified** (adjective) – confidential, secret, restricted, undisclosed, private गोपनीय
36. **At times** (phrase) – sometimes, occasionally, periodically, now and then कभी-कभी
37. **Fragile** (adjective) – delicate, weak, brittle, vulnerable, sensitive नाजुक
38. **Vulnerable** (adjective) – exposed, unprotected, defenseless, at risk असुरक्षित / कमजोर
39. **Formidable** (adjective) – powerful, strong, commanding, daunting, fearsome जबरदस्त
40. **Bastion** (noun) – stronghold, fortress, citadel, bulwark, defense किला / गढ़
41. **Insistence** (noun) – demand, assertion, emphasis, persistence, urging ज़ोर / आग्रह
42. **Transparency** (noun) – openness, clarity, honesty, accountability, visibility पारदर्शिता
43. **Due** (adjective) – appropriate, deserved, rightful, proper, suitable उचित

44. **Sticking point** (noun) – obstacle, disagreement, hurdle, issue, contention
बाधा
45. **Reportedly** (adverb) – (repeated) allegedly, according to reports, supposedly, as claimed बताया गया है
46. **Wield** (verb) – use, exercise, employ, apply, exert प्रयोग करना
47. **Unconvincing** (adjective) – weak, doubtful, implausible, unpersuasive, shaky
अविश्वसनीय / कमजोर
48. **Sub judice** (noun) – under judicial consideration, pending in court, legally unresolved न्यायिक विचाराधीन
49. **Evade** (verb) – avoid, escape, elude, dodge, sidestep बचना / टालना
50. **Examine** (verb) – inspect, review, investigate, analyse, scrutinise जांच करना
51. **Divulge** (verb) – reveal, disclose, share, expose, uncover उजागर करना
52. **Framework** (noun) – structure, outline, model, system, scheme ढांचा
53. **Ornithology** (noun) – study of birds, avian science, birdwatching science पक्षी विज्ञान
54. **Public domain** (noun) – an area of interest where information, products, etc. are available to everyone to see or use without paying सार्वजनिक क्षेत्र
55. **Cloud** (verb) – obscure, cover, blur, distort, conceal धुंधला करना / अस्पष्ट करना
56. **Misgivings** (noun) – doubts, apprehensions, suspicions, concerns, reservations संदेह / शंका

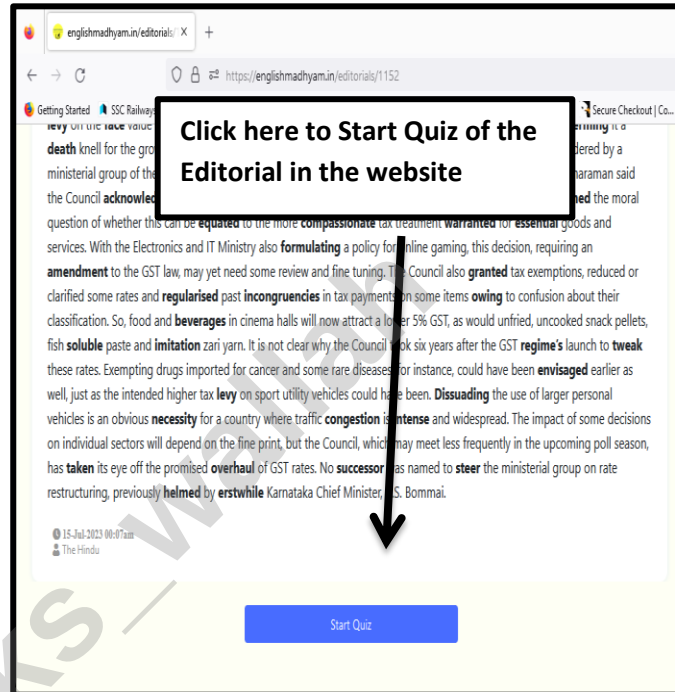
Summary of the Editorial

1. In the last five years, the Indian government has worked to develop the Andaman and Nicobar Islands as a strategic security bulwark in the Indo-Pacific region.
2. The Great Nicobar Island project includes revamped airfields, jetties, military bases, logistics hubs, and surveillance infrastructure.
3. Major proposed upgrades involve an International Container Transshipment Terminal, a greenfield airport, a township, and power plants.
4. The aim is to counter China's growing naval presence and influence in the Bay of Bengal, especially the PLA Navy's rapid modernization.
5. These initiatives are seen as crucial for national security and are considered long overdue given current geopolitical threats.
6. However, environmental and tribal concerns have significantly complicated the project's progress.
7. Civil society groups and conservationists argue that the development endangers indigenous tribes, such as the Shompen, and fragile marine and forest ecosystems.
8. Species like the Nicobar megapode bird and leatherback turtles are said to be at serious risk due to habitat disruption.
9. In 2023, the National Green Tribunal (NGT) asked the Environment Ministry to form a High-Powered Committee (HPC) to re-examine the project's clearances.
10. The HPC reportedly validated the project's environmental clearances, claiming they followed statutory rules — but the report hasn't been made public.
11. The lack of transparency has deepened mistrust; secrecy is being justified on strategic and security grounds, but critics see this as overreach.
12. The government has also invoked RTI Act exemptions and sub judice claims to avoid disclosing details about environmental and tribal impacts.
13. Even Rajya Sabha questions on the issue were avoided using the argument that the matter is before the courts.
14. The Wildlife Conservation Plan (WCP), allegedly based on expert frameworks, has also not been disclosed to the public.
15. The editorial concludes that while strategic development is essential, sidelining public engagement and transparency in an ecologically sensitive region risks long-term harm and alienates local communities.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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